Attachment 2

Summary of the Research Plan

To Renounce Liberty? A Public-Goods Experiment on (Un)Democratic Reversal

Janne Tukiainen | janne.tukiainen@utu.fi | Version 2.6 – proposed amendment | 20 October 2026

Purpose. The study examines whether citizens who support a binding decision without prior group approval later vote to restore that approval right when a public-service crisis recedes. It provides an incentive-compatible test of a narrow microfoundation of executive aggrandizement: a democratic ballot can weaken a constraint on a later decision, and a subsequent ballot can reinstate it.

Design and participants. The target is 300 adults in approximately 60-minute sessions at the UTU Choice Lab decision-making laboratory ~~and, if needed to accelerate recruitment, Tampere University's Decision-making Laboratory (DMLab)~~. Production rosters contain ~~10, 15, or 20~~ 5, 10, 15, or 20 participants and are divided into fixed matching pools of ~~10 or 15~~ 5, 10, or 15. Before each of ~~twenty~~ fifteen paid rounds, the software reshuffles ~~each pool~~ ten- and fifteen-person pools into anonymous five-person groups~~, permitting repeated interaction without stable teams or identifiable partners~~; a five-person pool retains the same members throughout. Ten rounds precede assignment and five follow it.

Task. Five participants vote between "Group approval required" and "Decision takes effect directly." The software then selects one participant uniformly at random to propose an equal allocation to a public-services fund and, possibly, a personal transfer. Under group approval, at least three of the other four must approve; rejection, including a two–two split, leads to individual allocations. Under direct implementation, the proposal takes effect without that vote. Decisions affect earnings.

Conditions. All participants begin in a fictional public-service crisis. In the first ten rounds, fund points produce 1.50 group points under group approval and 2.50 under direct implementation. Each pool is then assigned to *recovery*, in which conditions improve and the approval rate rises to 2.50, or *persistence*, in which the crisis and 1.50 rate continue. The direct rate and all rules remain fixed. This is deliberately one structural package: the description identifies the change and the rate makes it consequential.

Outcomes and analysis. The primary outcome is whether a participant who supported direct implementation in the final first-block round supports group approval in the final second-block round. The recovery–persistence comparison ~~is estimated at the pool level~~ uses individual outcomes with pool-level randomization and inference, using suitable econometric and randomization-based methods. Four-pool randomization sets balance treatment separately by pool size across sessions. Analysis accounts for pool size and, where estimable, checks results excluding five-person pools. Secondary evidence comes from decisions and eleven process questions. Twelve optional background items cover age, gender, education, financial strain, 2023 parliamentary vote, left–right placement, democratic support and satisfaction, strong-leader views, political efficacy, trust, and risk willingness.

Ethics and resources. Risks are minimal and primarily involve mild discomfort with unequal allocations and optional political questions. Participants register through ~~the host laboratory's participant system~~ UTU Choice Lab's UTU RPP/TOKA participant system and receive its general rules and privacy information; oTree separately records study-specific agreement before decisions. The information explains that the detailed research question is described fully after paid decisions, followed immediately by a debrief. Coded data are held on University of Turku IT servers in Finland. ~~The host laboratory separately holds recruitment and payment identities, never gives the research team any temporary identity-to-code link, and removes that link after payment under its procedure.~~ UTU RPP/TOKA does not receive experimental responses, payment information, or oTree participant codes. The research team pays participants immediately using a separate code-and-amount list, which is destroyed after payment reconciliation. Participants receive EUR 10 plus up to EUR 5 based on points.

Following the September 2026 ethical review, ~~pilots~~ technical tests will precede data collection planned for 1–31 October 2026. The first ten-person session, included within the 300 participants, serves as a behavioral pretest. At its end, an optional six-question form gathers anonymous feedback separately from experimental records. Compensation for 300 completed participants cannot exceed EUR 4,500~~, excluding any separate host-laboratory arrangements for timely arrivals who cannot be placed in a valid roster~~. Payment records are held separately from the research data by the research team.